

Accreditation Manual

ASI NA-MA-20-101-Version 2.0

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1. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

- 1.1 This manual presents the operational activities, duties, and responsibilities of ASI North America PB LLC (ASI North America) and Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) (accredited and applicant) during the Accreditation Cycle. It applies to all Accreditation activities and is binding for all parties involved in the process of Accreditation.
- 1.2 The manual applies to ASI North America PB LLC (ASI North America). For the purpose of this document, the acronym ASI NA will be used. Where reference is made to any other ASI entity, this will be specified. The acronym “ASI” alone is used to refer to the ASI-Assurance Services International.
- 1.3 This manual describes the general Accreditation-related service provision by ASI NA. It is primarily directed towards and specifies the requirements for CABs, based outside of the European Economic Area (EEA) and the UK, seeking to apply for and maintain Accreditation for certification schemes managed by ASI NA.
- 1.4 Other applicable operational activities and responsibilities of ASI NA and CABs are described in additional supporting ASI NA procedures and Accreditation Requirements and are referenced in this document under the relevant sections.
- 1.5 ASI NA may subcontract some activities related to the Accreditation process to partner organizations (see [Section 6](#)). However, ASI NA maintains full responsibility for all Accreditation activities carried out by any other partner organization on its behalf.

2. CHANGE HISTORY

Version number	Date of approval	Description of changes
1.0	19 August 2022	First publication. This Accreditation manual is based on 15 years of experience in implementing Accreditation processes by ASI NA’s sister organization, ASI Assurance Services International.
1.1	02 December 2022	Correction of cross-references in sections 17.5, 20.4 and Table 1 situation 9). No content changes.
2.0	12 December 2023	Refinement of the application process for new applicants clarifying that ASI is the starting point for TTAP. Extension of AC decision deadlines from 20 to 30 days. Removal of 30-days embargo for publishing suspension and withdrawal decisions. Additional clauses (20.5 & 20.6) and addition of term “Show Cause Notice” as per IAF MD7:2023 and IAF ID 15:2023 to allow entities to provide evidence to refute fraud allegations before imposing a Sanction or to take actions if fraud is detected at CH level. Clarification of clause 21.4 and minor changes to clause 16.4. Minor adjustments to match revised version 2.0 of ASI NA Findings Procedure (clause 17.3.2). Additions of clauses 21.20 and 22.12 addressing voluntary suspensions and withdrawals.

		Reordering of withdrawal conditions prior and post effective date (clause 22.8 and 22.9). Clarifications about financial probation (clause 23.3).
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3. TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

- 3.1 All terms and definitions, when not defined below, can be found in the ASI NA Glossary (ASI NA-INF-20-103).
- 3.2 **Accreditation Cycle:** Begins at the initial Accreditation Decision date or decision after a Reaccreditation Assessment and shall not be longer than five years. Before the end of a cycle, a Reaccreditation Assessment shall be conducted prior to cycle expiration.
- 3.3 **Accreditation Decision:** Decision on Granting, Maintaining, Extending, Reducing, Suspending and Withdrawing Accreditation.
- 3.4 **Accreditation Report:** The report prepared by ASI NA for its Accreditation Committee used to support the recommendation for an ASI NA Accreditation Decision.
- 3.5 **Accreditation Requirements:** Covers all the requirements the CAB has to fulfill to qualify for being Accredited against a specific scope and for maintaining such Accreditation. These requirements are set by ASI NA (ASI NA Accreditation Requirements) and others are set by the Scheme Owner (SO Accreditation Requirements).

Note: The application of the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program as operated by ASI Assurance Services International is a SO requirement applicable for various Voluntary Sustainability Schemes (VSS). ASI Assurance Services International GmbH (ASI GmbH or ASI Bonn) has been exclusively appointed by these VSS to oversee the integrity and credibility of their Certification Schemes worldwide and the claims made under them.

- 3.6 **ASI Assurance Services International:** ASI Assurance Services International - GmbH is a German based legal entity with its head office in Bonn. ASI Assurance Services International is an Assurance partner for leading VSS and sustainability initiatives around the world. ASI started as an international Accreditation Body for a single VSS and over the years, evolved into an “assurance provider” for multiple leading VSS, delivering a broader spectrum of credible Assurance Services tailored to clients’ needs. ASI Assurance Services International has been delivering Accreditation services since 2006 and is a sister company of ASI NA.
- 3.7 **ASI NA Accreditation Requirements:** Those Accreditation Requirements which are set by ASI NA. These are currently contained in the documents (information documents, policies, procedures, guidance and templates) listed in section 4 of ASI NA-INF-20-104 ‘Controlled List of Public ASI NA QMS Documents’ and published on the ASI NA website (www.asi-na.org). As far as the listed documents incorporate other publicly available documents by reference, further requirements set up in such other documents are also considered part of the ASI NA Accreditation Requirements.
- 3.8 **ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program (TTAP):** The ASI program that integrates Accreditation (Tier One) and complementary ASI Assurance Services (Tier Two) to ensure the overall integrity for ASI Clients and their claims:

- **Tier One:** Consists of the Accreditation of Conformity Assessment Bodies (CABs) by Participating Accreditation Bodies (Participating ABs) with mandatory ASI Assurance Services International participation in Accreditation Assessments.
- **Tier Two:** Consists of the complementary Assurance Services provided by ASI Assurance Services International.

Under the TTAP, ASI NA is a Participating Accreditation Body.

- 3.9 **SO Accreditation Requirements:** Those Accreditation Requirements which are set by the SO of the relevant scheme. These are contained in documents (e.g. standards, policies, procedures, advice notes, interpretations, etc.) published and maintained by the SO. As far as these documents incorporate other publicly available documents by reference (e.g., ISO standards), further requirements set in such other documents are also considered part of the SO Accreditation Requirements.
- 3.10 **Management System:** A set of policies, procedures, and practices an organization needs to follow in order to meet its own objectives. A Management System can address a single discipline or several disciplines, e.g. quality management (ISO 9000:2015), financial management or environmental management.
- 3.11 **Quality Management System (QMS):** Part of a Management System with regard to quality.
- 3.12 **Scheme Owner (SO):** Person or organization responsible for developing and maintaining a Certification Scheme or standard system and that owns the intellectual property, copyright, trademarks, and other rights to a Certification Scheme (adapted from ISO 17067:2013). SOs are responsible for developing, reviewing, revising, and interpreting their standards.
- 3.13 **Certification Scheme (Conformity Assessment Scheme):** Set of rules and procedures that describe the objects of conformity Assessments, identifying specific requirements and providing the methodology for performing conformity Assessments (from ISO 17000:2020). These refer to Certification Systems focused on specific Management Systems or specified products to which the same specified requirements, specific rules, and procedures apply.
- 3.14 **Reaccreditation Assessment:** Assessment performed to renew the Accreditation Cycle. This Assessment shall confirm the competence of the Conformity Assessment Body and shall cover all the relevant SO requirements for which the Conformity Assessment Body is Accredited. An Accreditation decision shall be made after the Reaccreditation Assessment.
- 3.15 **Errors of Fact (EOF):** A statement by a CAB claiming an inaccuracy or a mistake in the content of an ASI NA Assessment Finding or in the content of an ASI NA Accreditation Report.
- 3.16 **Extraordinary Event or Circumstance:** A circumstance beyond the control of the organization, commonly referred to as "Force Majeure" or "act of God", that may temporarily prevent ASI NA from carrying out oversight and planned Assessments of accredited CABs. Examples include war, strike, riot, political instability, geopolitical tension, terrorism, crime, pandemic, flooding, earthquake, malicious computer hacking, other natural or man-made disasters (adapted from IAF-ID 3: 2011).
- 3.17 **Sanction:** An action taken by ASI NA in response to a failure by the Conformity Assessment Body to meet its Accreditation obligations. A Sanction is not a Nonconformity.
- 3.18 **Show cause notice:** An order issued by ASI which requires an entity about which an allegation has been made - which can be a CAB or a CH - to provide evidence in writing to

contest allegations of fraud within a specific timeline, otherwise, Sanctions may be recommended.

4. ASSOCIATED DOCUMENTATION

The following documents are relevant for the application of this document.

4.1	Standards and Policies	Applicable SO requirements
4.2	Procedures, Guidelines	All ASI NA procedures and documents listed in the relevant sections of this Manual and published on the ASI NA website
4.3	Checklists, Templates, etc.	ASI NA Service Agreement ASI NA-TPL-20-102-Accreditation Application Form ASI NA-TPL-20-105-Scope Extension & Reduction Application Form ASI NA-CHK-20-106-Accreditation Transfer

5. GENERAL

- 5.1 ASI NA offers Accreditation services related to sustainability standards for CABs located outside of the European Economic Area/UK. Further, ASI NA participates as an Accreditation Body (AB) under the Two-Tier Assurance Program (TTAP) of ASI - Assurance Services International GmbH.
- 5.2 ASI NA is not a national Accreditation body (AB) and does not deliver Accreditation services in Europe to any CAB that is subject to REGULATION (EC) No 765/2008. CABs accredited by ASI NA shall not claim that their Accreditation falls under the jurisdiction of REGULATION (EC) 765/2008.
- 5.3 ASI NA may consider the results of independent Assessments performed by other ABs of CAB conformity against relevant standards but shall not be bound by these findings or by approval and evaluations by SOs.
- 5.4 ASI NA makes relevant CAB Accreditation-related decisions for the respective Voluntary Sustainability Schemes (VSS) after considering confirmation from ASI Assurance Services International (ASI) that the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program requirements have been met. ASI shall prepare and provide such confirmation in due course.
- 5.5 ASI NA operates in English. All information requested by ASI NA shall be submitted in English unless otherwise approved.

6. OUTSOURCING

- 6.1 ASI NA takes responsibility for all activities outsourced to another body and shall ensure that outsourced services are performed in line with ASI NA requirements and the provisions of ISO 17011:2017, including competence, impartiality and confidentiality requirements.
- 6.2 ASI NA shall not outsource Accreditation Decisions. These are made by assigned personnel or committees under enforceable arrangements with ASI NA.

- 6.3 ASI NA has enforceable agreements, including confidentiality and conflict of interest, with ASI Assurance Services International, covering the outsourced services detailed in **Table 1**.

Table 1: Accreditation Activity responsible entity

Accreditation activity	Entity	
	ASI NA	ASI Assurance Services International
Accreditation Administration		X
Application Processing		X
Accreditation agreements	X	
Assessments (and all related steps)		X
Assessment Sign-off (Decision to maintain Accreditation)	X	
Accreditation Decisions	X	
NC Management		X
Appeals Handling	X	X
Complaints Handling		X
Business integrity Risk analysis		X
Policy Making	X	

7. SCOPE OF ACCREDITATION

- 7.1 The Scope of Accreditation refers to the area(s) of competence for which a CAB's Certification Activity is covered by an ASI NA Accreditation Certificate. The Scope of Accreditation described on the ASI NA Accreditation certificate and its annex or on the ASI NA Website, specifies the following:
- 7.1.1 Scheme Owner,
 - 7.1.2 type of activities and/or products covered (ASI NA technical scope),
 - 7.1.3 standards and/or other normative documents and mandatory information with respect to the activities, services products and/or systems against which an accredited CAB can certify,
 - 7.1.4 the geographical area in which the CAB can perform Certification Activities (ASI NA geographical scope).
 - 7.1.5 All relevant information pertaining to the CAB's operations within the accredited Schemes (e.g. location of delivering offices) as required by ISO 17011:2017.

8. ACCREDITATION REQUIREMENTS

- 8.1 Accreditation shall only be granted and maintained if the CAB (applicant and accredited) commits to continually fulfill all the relevant Accreditation Requirements and to provide evidence of such fulfillment.
- 8.2 The CAB shall comply with:
 - 8.2.1 The SO Accreditation Requirements as defined in the normative documents of the respective SO.
 - 8.2.2 The ASI NA Accreditation Requirements published in the ASI NA Controlled List of Public Documents.
- 8.3 In the case that a SO has not defined Accreditation Requirements, ASI NA reserves the right to develop its own Accreditation Requirements for the respective Scheme to be able to carry out the independent oversight expected from ASI NA.
- 8.4 ASI NA shall only consider public official SO interpretations as SO Accreditation Requirements.

9. ACCREDITATION DECISIONS

- 9.1 Accreditation Decisions (decisions for Granting, Renewing, Extending and Reducing technical Scope, Suspending and/or Withdrawing Accreditation for all or part of the requested Scope) are made by the ASI NA Accreditation Committee (AC) unless otherwise specified in this Accreditation Manual.
- 9.2 When making an Accreditation Decision, the AC acts as a representative of ASI NA, and - as such - ASI NA takes full responsibility for Accreditation Decisions made by the AC. AC members have signed an agreement with ASI NA which requires them to adhere to ASI NA policies and procedures.
- 9.3 The AC shall have access to all ASI NA Assessment Reports and Nonconformities (NCs) issued, including ASI NA and CAB's responses to these.
- 9.4 An Accreditation Decision made by the AC is based on an Accreditation Report prepared by ASI NA. The Accreditation Report may include a recommendation, but any such decision recommendation is non-binding for the AC.
- 9.5 The decision-making process starts with the preparation of the Accreditation Report. Before the ASI NA Accreditation Report is sent to the AC, the report shall be shared with the CAB and the CAB shall have 10 calendar days to file any relevant and factual EOF on the content of the report.
- 9.6 If any EOF is filed within 10 calendar days, ASI NA shall review them and respond and/or amend the ASI NA Accreditation Report whenever relevant. The EOF and ASI NA responses shall be provided to the AC together with the Accreditation Report.
- 9.7 The AC shall communicate its decision to ASI NA within 30 calendar days of receipt of the Accreditation Report. ASI NA shall notify the CAB of this decision in writing within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, including a copy of the final Accreditation Report.

- 9.8 Other Accreditation Decisions, which may not require an Accreditation Report, may be delegated as follows:
- 9.8.1 Decisions for Maintaining Accreditation may be delegated to the ASI NA Chief Executive Officer (CEO) (or Chief Operating Officer (COO) in case of any potential Conflict of Interest (COI) or if delegated by the CEO).
 - 9.8.2 Decisions for extending or reducing geographical scope may be delegated to the ASI NA COO (or ASI NA CEO in case of any potential COI).
 - 9.8.3 Decisions for Extending or Reducing Technical Sub-scopes may be delegated to the ASI NA COO (or ASI NA CEO in case of any potential COI).
 - 9.8.4 Decisions, where reduction of scope, suspension or Withdrawal of Accreditation are voluntarily requested by the CAB, may be delegated to the ASI NA COO (or ASI NA CEO in case of any potential COI).
 - 9.8.5 Decisions where suspension or withdrawal of Accreditation is based on failure or inability to pay relevant invoices may be taken by the ASI NA COO or the ASI NA CEO based on recommendation from the ASI NA finance team.
- 9.9 Other decisions such as pausing or stopping the Accreditation process can occur during the application stage and can be made by the ASI NA COO (or ASI NA CEO in case of any potential COI).
- 9.10 For all Accreditation Decisions, ASI NA may specify additional requirements and conditions for CABs to manage ongoing risks to the integrity of their Accreditation.
- 9.11 The CAB may appeal Accreditation Decisions in accordance with the ASI NA Appeals Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-109). However, decisions such as pausing or stopping an Accreditation process cannot be appealed, as these are operational decisions and not Accreditation decisions.

10. APPLICATION FOR ACCREDITATION

- 10.1 Information about the application process is available on the ASI NA website (<https://www.asi-na.org>)
- 10.2 The applicant CAB shall be a legal entity that offers Conformity Assessment Services and that is qualified and competent to apply for Accreditation.
- 10.3 All information requested by ASI NA, including the application form and supporting documentation (application package), shall be completed in English.
- 10.4 The Application shall be made electronically via the application form available on the ASI NA website.

Applications for the ASI Two-Tier Assurance Program (TTAP)

- 10.5 Initial application shall be made with Assurance Services International (ASI).
- NOTE:** The ASI application form can be found [here](#).
- 10.6 Applicant CABs shall make contact with ASI NA to apply for Accreditation only when they have received a TTAP Approval Letter from ASI.

- 10.7 Once ASI NA has accepted the application documents and TTAP Approval Letter from ASI, the CAB shall sign the ASI NA Accreditation Agreement and formally commit to comply with all relevant Accreditation Requirements.

Applications for International Accreditation

- 10.8 Application shall be made electronically via the application form available on the ASI NA website.
- 10.9 ASI NA shall review the application completed by the CAB within 10 calendar days of its receipt, to determine the suitability of the application. Additional information and/or clarification may be requested from the applicant and an incomplete application may be rejected.
- 10.10 ASI NA may carry out an integrity risk analysis or due diligence review to evaluate any potential business risk related to the applicant.
- 10.11 ASI NA shall evaluate compliance of the application package and within 60 calendar days of receiving the application, ASI NA shall inform the applicant CAB whether the application is accepted or rejected.
- 10.12 Once ASI NA has accepted the application, the CAB shall sign the ASI NA Accreditation Agreement and formally commit to comply with all relevant Accreditation Requirements.

All Applications

- 10.13 Once the ASI NA Accreditation agreement has been signed, ASI NA shall start planning initial Assessment activities as detailed in section 13 below.
- 10.14 ASI NA may reject the application, or may end an Accreditation process if:
- 10.14.1 at any time during the application or initial Accreditation Assessment process, there is evidence of fraudulent behavior;
 - 10.14.2 the applicant intentionally provides false information or conceals information;
 - 10.14.3 any known violation of laws and regulations by the CAB that would bring ASI NA into disrepute; there is lack of compliance by the CAB with local regulations and legal requirements in the country or region of operation;
 - 10.14.4 there is regulatory or safety restrictions for ASI NA to implement its Accreditation process;
 - 10.14.5 the ASI NA due diligence review process reveals that the risks of a business relationship with the applicant is too high or may bring ASI NA into disrepute.
- 10.15 If a CAB wishes to reapply for Accreditation after a rejection, a new application shall be submitted, and a new application fee paid. For CABs under TTAP, this process will be coordinated with ASI. ASI NA may impose a cooldown period of up to two years before considering a new application can be submitted, and a new application fee shall be paid.
- 10.16 ASI NA may propose a reduced Scope of Accreditation, based on the results of relevant evaluations or Assessments. However, any other change in scope to the originally applied Accreditation scope is only possible if the CAB submits a formal scope extension/reduction request or application, as detailed in sections [18](#) and [19](#) below.
- 10.17 In the case of significant changes in any aspect of the applicant's status or operations during the Accreditation application process, ASI NA may request the applicant to submit a new

application and to pay a new application fee. Significant changes may include changes to the application scope, the CAB structure or procedures, which require the review of new documents and processes, etc.

- 10.18 The applicant CAB shall not communicate about their status as applicant until ASI NA places the name of applicant CAB on the ASI NA website.

11. PRELIMINARY VISIT

- 11.1 A one-day preliminary visit at the cost of the applicant CAB may be conducted, with the agreement of the CAB, in the following situations:
- 11.1.1 If, at time of the application, the applicant CAB has not performed any Conformity Assessment Activities or offered any similar services;
 - 11.1.2 If deemed necessary by ASI NA following identification of gaps or significant deficiencies with the submitted information that raise doubts about the CAB's competences to fulfill Accreditation Requirements; or
 - 11.1.3 Upon applicant request.
- 11.2 The purpose of a preliminary visit is to evaluate the suitability of the applicant's Quality Management System (QMS), to confirm the Scope of Accreditation, to determine the readiness of the CAB for undergoing Accreditation, to verify submitted documentation and for the applicant to better understand the ASI NA Accreditation process.
- 11.3 Following the visit, a report shall be prepared by ASI NA which summarizes the purpose and conclusions of the visit. Any issues identified will be recorded as Opportunities for Improvement (OFIs). During this process, ASI NA assessors shall not provide any advice or consultancy services at any time.

12. GENERAL ASSESSMENT REQUIREMENTS

NOTE: This section provides the generic requirements applicable to all types of ASI NA Accreditation Assessments.

- 12.1 ASI NA shall ensure that a qualified Assessor or team of Assessors is allocated for each Assessment. An Assessment Team can include a team leader, co-Assessors, trainees, Technical Experts and translators. Observers may join an Assessment, if previously agreed by the CAB, but they are not considered part of the team.
- 12.2 Before each Assessment, ASI NA shall inform the CAB about the Assessment Team composition and any Observers.
- 12.2.1 The CAB may submit a written objection against Observers within 5 calendar days of notification from ASI about the team composition and Observers.
 - 12.2.2 The CAB may submit a written objection against team member(s) in the case of an existing or perceived Conflict of Interest (COI) or threats to impartiality within 5 calendar days of notification from ASI about the team composition and shall include objective evidence to support any claims made.
 - 12.2.3 ASI NA shall review the objection(s) and may change the team composition if deemed justifiable, to mitigate or eliminate existing or perceived COI.

- 12.2.4 Due to timelines, CAB objections against Assessment Teams used in Short Notice and Unannounced Assessments may not be possible.
- 12.2.5 Notification of the ASI NA team for Witness Assessments is dependent on the CAB informing ASI in a timely manner about the CAB Audit dates.
- 12.3 ASI NA shall share an Assessment Agenda and Budget prior to any Assessment, except for Short-Notice or Unannounced Assessments. For Witness Assessments, the CAB shall notify ASI NA of its Audit dates and team members at least 30 calendar days prior to the Assessment and of its Audit agenda at least 14 calendar days prior to the Audit for head office Assessments and 7 calendar days for other Assessment types.
- 12.4 All ASI NA Assessments start with an opening meeting.
- 12.5 All Assessments shall be concluded with a closing meeting. If there is disagreement regarding any of the findings, they should be discussed and resolved at the closing meeting if possible. If not resolved, the disagreement shall be noted in the summary of findings (SOF) and in the final Assessment Report. The CAB is encouraged to involve their senior management in opening and closing meetings.
- 12.6 Opening and closing meetings may be held remotely if needed, with previous agreement of both parties.
- 12.7 ASI NA Assessment Report timelines for all Assessment types are given in calendar days and start at the closing meeting (see Figure 1).
 - 12.7.1 ASI NA shall share a SOF within 5 days of the closing meeting and the CAB shall have 10 days upon receipt of the SOF to file any Errors of Fact (EOF).
 - 12.7.2 All reports undergo a Technical Review (TR) and a sign-off process and, because of these, the grading and wording of findings may change between the SOF and the final report. Any changes shall be indicated in the final Assessment Report.
 - 12.7.3 ASI NA shall share a final Assessment Report with the CAB within 40 calendar days of the Assessment closing meeting.

Figure 1: ASI NA Assessment Report Timelines (in calendar days)



- 12.8 The CAB shall respond to ASI NA findings through the processes stipulated by the ASI NA Findings Management Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-107). The CAB shall carry out a Root Cause Analysis (RCA) to determine the cause and extent of the NC and provide evidence of effective implementation of Correction and Corrective Actions (CA) for each NC.
- 12.9 The CAB shall facilitate and cooperate in all ASI NA Assessments to ensure a constructive and professional Assessment environment. At minimum, the CAB shall:
 - 12.9.1 Provide unrestricted access to premises and documentation that pertain to the certification process, their operations and Scope of Accreditation.
 - 12.9.2 Provide access to premises and documentation for all members of the ASI team. Such access shall also include AOs, if ASI determines this is necessary.

- 12.9.3 Have enforceable arrangements with their clients to ensure ASI access to witness the CAB's Audit or to conduct a Compliance Assessment at the client's site, and to ensure that ASI NA has access to relevant documents.

13. INITIAL ACCREDITATION ASSESSMENTS AND PROCESS

- 13.1 Upon acceptance of the application, ASI NA shall share scheme-specific checklists with the CAB. The CAB shall complete and return them to ASI NA together with supporting documentation prior to the commencement of the Assessment to demonstrate that Accreditation Requirements are met.
- 13.2 ASI shall conduct three types of Assessments during the initial Accreditation process in any sequence:

1) Desk Review Assessment of the CAB application and documentation

- i. The Desk Review is the first Assessment and includes the review and evaluation of the applicant's documentation to determine:
 1. whether the CAB's documentation meets the applicable Accreditation Requirements and
 2. whether all the relevant Accreditation requirements have been suitably integrated into the CAB's Management System and operating procedures.
- ii. The scheduling of the Assessment should take place within 30 days after ASI has accepted the application.

2) Office Assessment(s) ((Head Office (HO) and Affiliate Office (AO))

- i. Office Assessments can be performed on-site or remotely at the discretion of ASI NA and based on the outcome of the Desk Review.
- ii. Office Assessments include the review and evaluation of the implementation of the CAB's QMS and documented procedures. The aim is to determine that the CAB has the resources, systems and competence to carry out the Conformity Assessment Activities in accordance with all relevant Accreditation Requirements.
- iii. AOs may also be part of the initial Office Assessment as deemed necessary by ASI NA, depending on the nature of activities carried out by the AO and the extent of control exercised by the CAB.
- iv. A CAB's key personnel shall be available to the Assessment Team during Office Assessments.

3) Witness Assessment(s) for each Technical Scope of Accreditation.

- i. ASI NA shall conduct at least one Witness Assessment per technical scope to verify the competence of the applicant CAB to conduct Audits of its clients for each scope. It is at ASI NA's sole discretion to determine if all or fewer scopes need to be witnessed.
- ii. For applicant CABs, the Witness Assessment shall be concluded after the CAB Audit report has been finalized and relevant CAB records of technical reviews and decision-

making processes are sent to ASI NA for evaluation. This implies a possible deviation from the normal ASI NA deadline for report finalization. ASI NA shall ensure that its Witness Assessment report is finalized no more than 20 days from the receipt of the above stated CAB records.

- iii. Certain types of CAB Audits may not be suitable for initial Witness Assessments (e.g. Audit scope not covering full technical scope, transfer of certificates among CABs, etc.). ASI NA may reject witnessing such Audits.

- 13.3 ASI NA reserves the right to conduct additional Assessments besides the ones mentioned in 13.2 above. In such cases a justification shall be provided.
- 13.4 If the CAB applies for an Accreditation scope covering more than one Scheme, ASI NA may combine the HO Assessments (unless the CAB requests otherwise).
- 13.5 The applicant CAB shall respond to any requests for clarification, additional documents and/or information and to any NCs within the deadlines indicated by ASI NA.
- 13.6 ASI NA places the names of applicant CABs on the ASI NA website following the closure of all major NCs from the HO Assessment. From that moment onwards, the applicant may advertise their status as an applicant, inform any clients or potential clients of their applicant status.
- 13.7 ASI NA announces all planned Assessments on its website after the CAB has been added to the website as an applicant.
- 13.8 If the applicant CAB is unable to achieve Accreditation within two years of the date of reception by ASI NA of the initial application package, ASI NA may stop and cancel the Accreditation process. A full reapplication may be required in such instances. Exceptional extension of this two-year window may be justified and approved by ASI NA following formal and justified written request by the applicant.

14. INITIAL ACCREDITATION DECISION PROCESS

- 14.1 Accreditation shall not be granted until all NCs raised by ASI NA have been closed
- 14.2 An initial Accreditation decision is required following:
 - 14.2.1 An Accreditation Transfer Process as described in the ASI NA Accreditation Transfer Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-100).
 - 14.2.2 An initial Accreditation Assessment process as described in section 13 above.
- 14.3 If, after the completion of the initial Accreditation Assessments, ASI NA concludes that the CAB's Certification system meets all Accreditation Requirements, including closure of all NCs, ASI NA shall prepare an Accreditation Report for the AC, recommending Accreditation.
- 14.4 Before the Accreditation Report is sent to the AC, the report shall be shared with the CAB and the CAB shall be given 10 calendar days for an opportunity to point out any potential EOF.
- 14.5 The AC shall communicate its decision to ASI NA within 30 calendar days of receipt of the Accreditation Report.

- 14.6 If the AC makes a positive Accreditation decision, ASI NA shall notify the CAB of this decision in writing within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, including a copy of the final Accreditation Report.
- 14.7 If the AC decides against Accreditation, ASI shall notify the CAB within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, and of the basis for the decision. The CAB may appeal the decision in accordance with the ASI NA Appeals Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-109).
- 14.8 If, during the AC review and decision process, new evidence or risks are brought to the attention of ASI NA regarding risks or the performance of the applicant CAB, such information shall be considered and ASI NA may at any time inform the AC and amend the Accreditation report accordingly. In such a case, 10 additional calendar days shall be given to the AC for making a decision.

15. NOTIFICATION OF ACCREDITATION AND ACCREDITATION CYCLES

- 15.1 Accreditation is notified in the form of an Accreditation Certificate and an annex signed by the ASI NA COO or CEO. The issue date marks the start of the first five-year Accreditation Cycle.
- 15.2 Accreditation Cycles are renewed every five years after a successful Reaccreditation process - including a positive AC decision - has taken place prior to cycle expiration.
- 15.3 A new certificate is only issued if there are changes in the CAB name, address or Certification Scheme(s) covered by the Accreditation. In the case of geographical or technical scope changes, only the certificate annex and/or ASI NA website is updated accordingly.
- 15.4 A digital version of the certificate is shared with each accredited CAB via email. Upon CAB request, hard copies can be shared.
- 15.5 The accredited CAB shall ensure that all Accreditation-related claims are within the scope included in the Accreditation Certificate.
- 15.6 The CAB shall only make use of the ASI NA Logo and ASI NA Accreditation Claims as outlined in the Policy on ASI NA Trademark Requirements (ASI NA-POL-20-108).
- 15.7 In the case of a transfer of Accreditation, the initial Accreditation cycle shall be maintained as per ASI NA Accreditation Transfer Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-100).

16. MAINTAINING ACCREDITATION

- 16.1 To ensure that an accredited CAB continues to operate in compliance with the Accreditation Requirements, ASI NA monitors and evaluates the CAB's competence and Conformity throughout the five-year Accreditation Cycle via surveillance Assessments.
- 16.2 The first HO surveillance Assessment should be carried out within 6 months following the initial Accreditation issue date.
- 16.3 For each surveillance Assessment, ASI NA Assessment teams shall provide a recommendation in each Assessment Report as to whether the evidence from the Assessment supports either maintaining, suspending or reducing Accreditation.

16.4 Annual surveillance includes:

- 1) Assessment of HO and a sample of AOs where applicable;
- 2) Witness and/or Compliance Assessment(s);
- 3) Any other Assessments such as Desk Review and NC verification as considered necessary by ASI to confirm that the CAB is operating in accordance with the Accreditation Requirements.

Note: Surveillance Office Assessments are normally less extensive than initial and Reaccreditation Assessments as they only cover a subset of the Accreditation requirements. In the five-year cycle, all Accreditation requirements shall be covered.

16.5 ASI NA shall provide the accredited CAB with an annual Assessment plan for Office, affiliate and Witness/Compliance Assessments.

16.6 ASI NA may conduct Extra Assessments in addition to the surveillance Assessment program to investigate Incidents and/or Complaints or the outcome of an earlier Assessment or under other circumstances as deemed necessary.

16.7 ASI NA may conduct Unannounced Assessments as part of or outside of its surveillance Assessment program in order to address heightened risk or allegations of serious violations or negligence of Accreditation Requirements.

16.8 The CAB shall ensure that ASI NA can conduct Witness and Compliance Assessments of the sample of CAB clients selected by ASI NA.

16.9 In justified cases, HO Assessment intervals may be extended. In the intervening year where no HO Assessment takes place, the CAB shall, at a minimum, submit its Internal Audit report(s) and management review minutes and inform ASI NA of any changes to the organization's QMS. ASI may request additional information at any time.

17. REACCREDITATION ASSESSMENT

17.1 The objective of the Reaccreditation Assessment is to renew the Accreditation Cycle, confirm the competence of the CAB and to evaluate the CAB's management and Certification systems in full, taking into consideration all Assessment knowledge and information gathered during the five-year cycle.

17.2 A Reaccreditation Assessment of the CAB's full management and certification systems covering **all the relevant Accreditation requirements** for which the CAB is accredited, should be carried out approximately nine months before the end of the Accreditation Cycle.

17.3 The date of the Reaccreditation HO Assessment closing meeting is the cut-off date for NCs that require a response from the CAB before an Accreditation Cycle can be renewed.

- 17.3.1 All NCs raised by ASI NA in previous Assessments and during the Reaccreditation HO Assessment, shall be closed before Reaccreditation can be granted. Deadlines for minor NCs shall be shortened to ensure these are addressed and closed before Reaccreditation can be granted.

- 17.4 Once all NCs have been addressed as per 17.3.1 above, ASI NA shall prepare an Accreditation Report for the AC also covering key conclusions of Assessments carried out in the cycle and the recommendation for the decision.
- 17.5 The CAB shall be provided with the opportunity to submit any potential EOF on the Accreditation Report within 10 calendar days of receipt. ASI NA shall address any EOF submitted by the CAB and also provide this information to the AC as part of the reaccreditation reporting.
- 17.6 The AC shall communicate its decision to ASI NA within 30 calendar days of receipt of the report.
- 17.7 If the AC makes a positive Reaccreditation decision, ASI NA shall notify the CAB within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC.
- 17.8 If the Accreditation Cycle expires before the decision-making process can be finalized due to a CAB failure to close all NCs, the CAB shall be suspended. Suspension may be lifted by ASI NA, without AC involvement, once the CAB demonstrates conformance and closes all open NCs in order for the Reaccreditation process to continue.
- 17.9 If a major NC raised during the Reaccreditation Assessment is appealed or is under Appeal investigation during an Accreditation Cycle renewal process, the AC review shall be postponed until the Appeal is closed. The CAB's Accreditation will remain valid.
- 17.10 If the AC decides against Reaccreditation, ASI NA shall notify the CAB within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC of the basis for the decision and any next steps on behalf of the CAB and ASI NA. The CAB may appeal the decision in accordance with the ASI NA Appeals Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-109).

18. SCOPE EXTENSION

- 18.1 Technical and geographical scope extensions may only occur upon CAB request.
- 18.2 Applications shall be made electronically via the CAB Portal or, via the Scope Extension and Reduction Application Form (ASI NA-TPL-20-105).
- 18.3 A scope extension application may be evaluated:
- 18.3.1 during a regular surveillance Office Assessment if the request it is sent to ASI NA at least 90 calendar days before the scheduled Assessment; or
 - 18.3.2 at a different time if the 90-calendar day notification cannot be met.
- 18.4 After reviewing the application, ASI NA shall determine the duration and type of Assessments that will be needed. For technical scope extensions, a Witness Assessment shall always be required.
- 18.5 Scope extensions require the following decision-making:
- 18.5.1 For a technical scope extension, an Accreditation Report shall be prepared for the AC.
 - 18.5.2 For Technical Subscope extension, ASI NA CEO or COO shall take the decision without AC involvement.

- 18.5.3 For geographical scope extension, ASI NA CEO or COO shall take the decision without AC involvement.
- 18.6 For geographical scope extensions, the following process shall be applied:
- 18.6.1 The CAB is required to provide evidence that it has access to sufficient resources to manage the geographical scope(s), including personnel, languages, Management Systems, AOs or subcontractors, arrangements to cover potential liabilities from Conformity Assessment Activities in the newly proposed countries, etc.
- 18.6.2 ASI NA may specify additional conditions during the geographical scope extension to monitor CAB expansion activities and the sufficient access to resources to ensure there are no risks to the integrity of the issued Accreditation.
- 18.6.3 ASI NA may decide not to conduct an additional Assessment if:
- 1) an Accreditation Decision can be made based on current knowledge of a CAB's system if it is accredited for other ASI NA programs;
 - 2) the scope extension is minor (e.g. a country in a region where the CAB already operates); or
 - 3) there is an upcoming Office Assessment at which this can be evaluated.
 - 4) For countries representing significant legal risk additional scope extension process may be defined by ASI NA. Such countries shall be defined by ASI NA through a due diligence process.
- 18.7 Upon a favorable scope extension decision, ASI NA shall update the certificate annex and its website including the new technical and/or geographical scope and share the revised digital version with the CAB via email.

19. SCOPE REDUCTION

- 19.1 Technical and geographical scope reductions can occur upon ASI NA recommendation or upon CAB voluntary request.
- 19.2 ASI NA may recommend a scope reduction to the CAB to lift a Suspension decision that was based on evidence from one or more surveillance Assessments, from a Reaccreditation Assessment or from lack of compliance with local regulations in the country of operations.
- 19.3 Scope reductions based on ASI recommendation require the following decision-making:
- 19.3.1 For technical scope reduction, an Accreditation Report shall be prepared for the AC as per section 9.
- 19.3.2 For geographical scope reduction, ASI NA COO may make the decision without AC involvement.
- 19.4 A CAB may voluntarily reduce its Accreditation for all or for parts of its technical and/or geographical scope by notifying ASI NA three months in advance of the desired Effective Date of the Reduction of Scope. The consequences of a Reduction of Scope are the same to those of a Withdrawal (see section 22 below).
- 19.5 A CAB that has voluntarily reduced its Scope of Accreditation may re-apply to extend the scope again at any time, by following the process set out in section 18.

20. SANCTIONS

- 20.1 If a CAB fails to comply with some ASI NA Accreditation Requirements or is/has been in breach of the terms of the ASI NA Accreditation Agreement, ASI NA may impose Sanctions on the CAB.
- 20.2 Potential sanctions are presented below in order of least to most severity:
- 20.2.1 Formal warning;
 - 20.2.2 Intensification of surveillance of CAB activity (frequency or duration) at the expense of the CAB;
 - 20.2.3 Suspension of Accreditation;
 - 20.2.4 Reduction of Accreditation scope;
 - 20.2.5 Withdrawal of Accreditation.
- 20.3 If a Sanction is imposed, the CAB is required to provide an analysis of the cause(s) that led to the Sanction, which may serve as a basis for addressing and eliminating the imposed Sanction. If the CAB fails to comply with this obligation, ASI NA shall impose another Sanction which shall be more severe than the previous one (e.g. after a formal warning, an intensification of surveillance or a Suspension may be imposed).
- 20.4 The order of sanctions presented in 20.2 above does not necessarily indicate the order of progression of sanctions. ASI NA may impose a more severe initial Sanction if warranted by the particular circumstances of the individual case and vice versa. Similarly, ASI NA may move from a less severe initial sanction, directly to the most severe (e.g. from Formal Warning to Suspension) if warranted by the particular circumstances of the individual case.
- 20.5 ASI NA shall issue a Show Cause Notice as a preliminary step before a Sanction is imposed when there are allegations of fraudulent behavior to allow the entity about which an allegation has been made to provide evidence to refute the allegations within 15 working days of the notice received.
- 20.6 CABs shall take actions to preserve the integrity of the Scheme by withdrawing or limiting certification where appropriate or when requested by ASI NA, if evidence of fraud is detected or if fraud allegations could not be refuted at the CH level. Failure to comply with this may result in sanctions from ASI NA.
- 20.7 Examples of situations leading to Sanctions and the minimal Sanctions which shall be imposed by ASI NA, as well as the typical progression of Sanctions are presented in [Annex 1](#).

21. SUSPENSION OF ACCREDITATION

- 21.1 Suspension of Accreditation places temporary restrictions on the services a CAB may provide within the Scope of its Accreditation. Suspension can be for all or part of the Scope of Accreditation. The temporary restrictions and conditions shall be specified in the notice of Suspension from ASI NA. In general, the following shall always be applicable during the suspension period:
- 21.2 Within the scope of the Suspension, the CAB **shall NOT**:
- 21.2.1 issue any new ASI accredited Certificate
 - 21.2.2 issue any new scope extension (no addition of sites to existing certificates).

- 21.2.3 enter into new agreements for Certification.
- 21.3 During the Suspension, the CAB shall:
 - 21.3.1 continue to conduct surveillance Audits necessary to maintain existing Certifications;
 - 21.3.2 Continue to address NCs raised by ASI NA within their respective timelines.
- 21.4 The CAB may continue to conduct Audits required for initial and recertification and issue a certificate if the certification process began prior to the date of the Suspension and the CAB has obtained prior written approval from ASI, but shall not otherwise issue any new ASI accredited Certifications or scope extensions within the scope of the Suspension.
- 21.5 ASI NA shall continue to conduct surveillance Assessments for a CAB and its clients throughout the period of a CAB's Suspension.
- 21.6 Fees paid will not be refunded upon Suspension. Annual fees must be paid normally during the period of Suspension.
- 21.7 For Assessment-related Suspensions (triggered by conclusions from an Assessment), the CAB shall be informed about a possible Suspension upon receipt of the final Assessment Report at the latest.
- 21.8 For non-Assessment-related Suspensions (e.g. not responding to major NCs in time), the CAB shall be informed by receiving a formal notification specifying the intent to suspend and the beginning of the Suspension process.
- 21.9 For each Suspension decision (except for non-payment of fees - see section 23.4), ASI NA shall prepare an Accreditation Report for the AC explaining the reasons leading to Suspension, a justification of the scope (technical and/or geographical) proposed for Suspension, the conditions for lifting the Suspension and any other relevant information considered material for the recommendation.
- 21.10 Before the Accreditation Report is sent to the AC, the CAB will have the opportunity to submit potential EOF within 5 calendar days.
- 21.11 Within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report, the AC shall communicate its decision to ASI NA.
- 21.12 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, ASI NA shall notify the CAB of the Suspension in writing. The notice of Suspension shall include the Effective Date of Suspension, duration, reasons, scope and conditions or any additional actions and deadlines for conformance required by the CAB. ASI NA shall also inform ASI and the relevant SO at this time.
- 21.13 The CAB may appeal the Suspension decision in accordance with the ASI NA Appeals Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-109)..
- 21.14 ASI NA shall update the record of accredited CABs on its website and publish a short summary of the grounds for Suspension. The CAB will be given an opportunity to review the wording of the news item.

- 21.15 A Suspension shall be effective for a maximum period of six months. The suspended CAB may require an extension of this period providing in writing a clear justification to ASI NA. The extension shall be approved by ASI NA COO if the justification is accepted. Extension may also be granted following an ASI NA Assessment that recommends more time to verify the effectiveness of Corrective Actions taken.
- 21.16 Failure to satisfactorily address the causes that led to Suspension within the specified deadline is grounds for initiating Withdrawal of Accreditation.
- 21.17 Suspension shall be lifted after ASI NA has verified (e.g. via Assessment) that the conditions specified in the notice of Suspension have been adequately met.
- 21.18 For lifting Suspension, an Accreditation Report shall be prepared and submitted to the AC to issue a decision within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report. This report will not need to be shared with the CAB for review and to submit any potential EOF.
- 21.19 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, ASI NA shall notify the CAB in writing. Once the Suspension has been lifted, ASI NA shall update the record of accredited CABs on its website and inform the SO.
- 21.20 The CAB can request a voluntary Suspension of Accreditation (partial or in full) by sending a written request to ASI including a justification. If ASI agrees to the request, it shall determine the conditions for lifting Suspension. Once all conditions are met, ASI shall lift the Suspension without AC involvement. The conditions outlined in sections 21.14 - 21.16 apply.

22. WITHDRAWAL OF ACCREDITATION

- 22.1 In the event of withdrawal of Accreditation, ASI NA shall prepare an Accreditation Report for the AC explaining the reasons leading to Withdrawal of Accreditation and any other relevant information considered material for the recommendation.
- 22.2 Before the Accreditation Report is sent to the AC, the CAB will have the opportunity to submit any potential EOF that may be part of the Accreditation Report within 10 calendar days.
- 22.3 Within 10 calendar days of receipt of the report, the AC shall communicate its decision to ASI AC.
- 22.4 Within 5 calendar days of the decision of the AC, ASI NA shall notify the CAB of the Withdrawal in writing. The notice of Withdrawal shall include the Effective Date of Withdrawal, a clear statement of the reasons for the decision and the final Accreditation Report. ASI NA shall also inform ASI and the relevant SO at this time.
- 22.5 The CAB may appeal the Withdrawal Decision in accordance with the ASI NA Appeals Procedure.
- 22.6 ASI NA shall make public notice of the Withdrawal decision on its website.
- 22.7 Withdrawal shall lead to a termination of the ASI NA Accreditation Agreement.
- 22.8 Upon receipt of the notice of Withdrawal, the CAB shall:

- 22.8.1 provide ASI NA within 5 calendar days a list of all clients affected, including contact information for each client.
 - 22.8.2 inform within 15 calendar days all subcontractors, affiliates, partners and clients in writing of the Withdrawal of Accreditation and its related implications (e.g. requirement for client to return certificate, process of transfer to other CABs, etc.).
 - 22.8.3 provide evidence to ASI NA of having contacted all of the above within 5 calendar days of the contact.
- 22.9 Following the effective date of Withdrawal, the CAB shall:
- 22.9.1 cease making reference to its accredited status and discontinue to use the ASI NA name and Trademarks.
 - 22.9.2 return the Accreditation Certificate to ASI NA, if a printed copy was obtained.
 - 22.9.3 Unless there are SO requirements allowing a different period, CAB certificates existing at the time of Withdrawal may remain valid for a period of 90 days, subject to confirmation by ASI NA, to permit CHs to enter into an agreement with another accredited CAB. The ASI NA CEO or COO may grant an extension of this transition period.
- 22.10 A withdrawn Accreditation cannot be reinstated. If a CAB wishes to be accredited again, it must apply for initial Accreditation.
- 22.11 For a period of 24 months from the date of the Withdrawal notification, ASI NA will not accept applications from a CAB from which Accreditation has been withdrawn or from a new entity linked and/or substantially staffed with personnel associated with a CAB with a withdrawn Accreditation.
- 22.12 The CAB can request a voluntary Withdrawal of Accreditation by sending a written request to ASI including a justification, the requested effective date and a transition plan for their clients. Actions in clause 22.8 should be completed prior to the effective date and actions in clause 22.9 following the effective date.

23. COST OF ACCREDITATION

- 23.1 Accredited and applicant CABs shall pay fees as shown in the current Fee schedule (ASI NA-INF-20-110).
- 23.2 Payment of any invoice is due within 30 days of the issue date. A monthly 1% interest charge will be included for each delayed month, backdating to the initial invoice date. This 1% interest will continue to accumulate until the invoice is paid in full.
- 23.3 The CAB shall be put on “financial probation” if a payment has not been received within 60 days after the invoice date (issue date). A CAB on financial probation may not:
- 23.3.1 apply for or continue with Scope of Accreditation extension,
 - 23.3.2 continue with the Accreditation application process,
 - 23.3.3 receive an ASI NA certificate for initial Accreditation, or
 - 23.3.4 apply for additional ASI NA programs.

Note: While on financial probation, a CAB can continue to operate ASI NA-accredited programs.

23.4 Suspension due to non-payment of fees

- 23.4.1 The CAB shall be directly suspended by ASI NA, without involvement of the AC, if an invoice and the related interest accumulated remains unpaid for 120 calendar days after the invoice date (issue date). For applicant CABs, this will result in the Suspension of the application process.
- 23.4.2 ASI NA will send the CAB written notice of the Suspension decision and information will be placed on the ASI NA website. ASI will also inform the relevant SO.
- 23.4.3 Suspension will be lifted promptly upon receipt of payment. For this type of decision, section 20 on Sanctions does not apply nor does the preparation of an Accreditation Report for the AC.

24. INFORMATION DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS

- 24.1 Copies of all materials and information relating to the CAB's Certification Activity shall be made available to ASI NA upon request within the timelines specified in the request.
- 24.2 The CAB shall make all requested documentation available to ASI NA before an Assessment. This shall be done via the ASI NA CAB Portal, by giving remote access to the CAB's Management System or by other mutually agreeable means, e.g. via Dropbox or via email.
- 24.3 The CAB shall keep all required information fields related to their AOs updated in the ASI NA CAB Portal. Relevant changes (i.e. new offices and changes of the type of activities offices carry out) shall be entered within 30 days from the date the information has changed. Other information (such as number of certificate holders each office manages) can be updated annually, before the annual HO Assessment.
- 24.4 The CAB shall inform ASI NA about changes that can have significant impact on how their organization fulfills the necessary requirements and other terms and conditions associated with Accreditation. Such information should be disclosed to ASI NA before the changes take place. Failure to notify ASI NA in a timely manner may result in Sanctions. Significant changes may include, but are not limited to:
 - 24.4.1 changes in ownership (legal entity), name, email address, website address, visiting or mailing address, telephone number.
 - 24.4.2 organizational changes or restructuring of key management personnel such as administrative (e.g. billing) or technical/program management.
 - 24.4.3 Significant changes in the CAB's operations management systems
- 24.5 ASI NA shall evaluate each case and decide whether an additional on-site Assessment is needed to evaluate Conformity with Accreditation Requirements or if the documentation submitted is sufficient.

25. REVISION OF ACCREDITATION REQUIREMENTS

25.1 ASI NA Accreditation Requirements

- 25.1.1 The CAB shall comply at all times with the current Accreditation Requirements, including new requirements or changes to them, within the deadlines stipulated by ASI NA.
- 25.1.2 ASI NA shall inform the CAB of any changes to its Accreditation Requirements and the Effective Date of the changes.
- 25.1.3 ASI NA may at its discretion, conduct public consultations on proposed major modifications to Accreditation Requirements to request comments by interested parties. Consultation periods for new or revised ASI NA procedures shall be 30 calendar days. In some cases, ASI NA may extend this deadline.
 - 25.1.3.1 A review is considered major when it significantly affects the working routines of a CAB.
 - 25.1.3.2 Minor changes shall not be preceded by a public consultation.

25.2 SO Accreditation Requirements

- 25.2.1 ASI NA shall carry out Assessments to evaluate transition for major revisions of SO Accreditation standards. To minimize disruption and reduce additional cost, ASI NA may evaluate these during the CAB's upcoming annual HO Assessment, unless agreed differently with the SO.
- 25.2.2 ASI NA shall ensure that CABs are assessed for transition to the new/revised standards within six months from the publication date.
- 25.2.3 Decisions on transition to new/updated standards shall be made by ASI NA CEO or COO.
- 25.2.4 All major NCs shall be closed before a revised Accreditation Certificate annex can be issued.
- 25.2.5 Once transition to the new/revised standard has been successfully evaluated and major NCs are closed, the ASI NA website and/or certificate annex will be amended with a reference to the new/revised standards.

26. DISPUTES (APPEAL, COMPLAINTS)

- 26.1 If the applicant or accredited CAB disagrees with ASI NA's findings or decisions at any point in the Accreditation process, they may submit an Appeal. See ASI NA Appeals Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-109) for more details.
- 26.2 If any person or organization wishes to express dissatisfaction to ASI NA relating to its activities, the activities of subcontracted third parties, or those of an accredited CAB or of a certificate holder, they may submit a formal Complaint as per ASI NA Complaints Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-111).
- 26.3 Incidents that threaten the reputation and/or integrity of the ASI NA Accreditation program and/or its associated Certification Schemes and that are not already considered under the relevant ASI NA procedures for Complaints and Appeals, can be reported (also anonymously) to ASI NA.

27. NON-CONFORMITIES (NCs) AND CORRECTIVE ACTIONS

- 27.1 If ASI NA determines through an Assessment that a CAB is not in conformance with relevant Accreditation Requirements or with the CAB's own policies and procedures, ASI NA shall provide the CAB with the opportunity to make corrections and take Corrective Actions by raising relevant NCs.
- 27.2 NCs may arise from various sources (e.g. complaints, incident verifications, etc.), but these shall only be confirmed through an Assessment carried out by a qualified assessor and shall be based on evidence of non-fulfillment of an applicable requirement.
- 27.3 NCs are registered and managed through the ASI NA CAB Portal. CABs shall respond to NCs only via the CAB Portal.
- 27.4 The CAB shall carry out a Root Cause Analysis (RCA) to determine the cause before taking Corrective Action.
- 27.5 NCs shall be managed according to the ASI NA Findings Management Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-107).

28. PUBLIC NOTICE AND INFORMATION

- 28.1 ASI NA shall maintain a list of applicant and accredited CABs on its website. This list includes information such as: CAB's name, address, Accreditation status, technical/geographical scope, delivering offices, date of initial Accreditation, certificate of Accreditation, records of Assessments and Assessment Reports and a history of Suspensions, as well as contact data as specified by the CAB (main contact name, address, email address, phone number and website).
- 28.2 ASI NA may publish Assessment Reports to the extent permitted by the ASI NA service agreement.

29. TRANSFER OF ACCREDITATION

- 29.1 If an accredited CAB ("transferor CAB") wishes to transfer its Accreditation to another entity CAB ("transferee CAB"), the ASI NA Transfer Procedure (ASI NA-PRO-20-100) shall be used.
- 29.2 The following principles shall apply:
 - 29.2.1 If the transferee CAB (new entity) is already accredited by ASI NA for the relevant geographic and technical scope,
 - 29.2.1.1 Both CABs may arrange for a transfer of certificates in accordance with the relevant Certification Scheme and the CAB's contracts with its clients. In such situations a transfer of Accreditation between the CABs may not be required.
 - 29.2.1.2 The CABs shall notify ASI NA of any significant transfer events and information as per section 25 above.
 - 29.2.1.3 The transferor CAB reduces Scope or withdraws Accreditation, and the provisions of sections 19 or 22 apply after the certificate transfer.

- 29.2.2 If the transferee CAB (new entity) is not ASI NA accredited for the relevant Certification Scheme, the entity CAB shall apply for ASI NA Accreditation under section 10.
- 29.2.3 If the transferee CAB (new entity) is partially accredited (e.g. only wants to add a technical scope), they shall apply for a scope extension as per section 18, unless the situation below applies.
- 29.2.4 If the transferee CAB (new entity) is not an ASI accredited CAB and : a) is under common ownership and control as the transferor CAB, or b) has been a subcontractor of the transferor CAB and has managed a substantial part of the Certification Activities under the relevant Accreditation for the previous 18 months, then ASI NA may apply a simplified Accreditation transfer process, which shall be communicated to the CAB in writing, on a case by case basis.
- 29.2.5 In the case of minor changes (e.g. change of CAB's name) that do not involve transfer of Accreditation to another legal entity, it is at ASI NA's discretion to note the changes on the basis of submitted documentation.

29.3 The transferee CAB shall be responsible for addressing all open ASI NA NCs and CFUs from the transferor CAB, as requested by ASI NA.

30. EXTRAORDINARY EVENTS OR CIRCUMSTANCES AFFECTING ABs, CABs AND CHs

- 30.1 In the event of any extraordinary circumstances that may temporarily prevent ASI NA or CABs from operating within their Accreditation, and in the event that Schemes, ASI NA or CABs are affected by the extraordinary circumstance, the following shall apply:
 - 30.1.1 ASI NA shall carry out a risk analysis of the situation to investigate the impact and risk to Accreditation processes and conformity Assessment activities, following its Risk Management Procedures and guidance provided in IAF Informative Document 3 (IAF ID 3:2011).
 - 30.1.2 On a case-by-case basis, following the risk analysis, ASI NA shall outline the steps it will take and shall communicate its position within 10 business days of notification of the extraordinary circumstance.
 - 30.1.3 If the risk of continuing Accreditation services is considered high and/or alternative methods of Assessment to verify conformity are not possible, as a first step, ASI shall suspend its activities in the affected region until the situation is considered resolved.
 - 30.1.4 If the extraordinary circumstance persists and ASI is unable to recuperate and therefore no longer able to provide Accreditation services on a permanent basis, ASI shall inform the SOs and CABs and proceed with the reduction of the scope of Accreditation of CABs to exclude the affected area in line with regulatory requirements.
- 30.2 CABs shall establish a documented process for handling extraordinary circumstances. The process shall at minimum:
 - 30.2.1 Require a risk Assessment for continuing certification activities;
 - 30.2.2 Outline steps it shall take in the event of an extraordinary circumstance;

- 30.2.3 Include potential short-term methods of assessing conformity of organizations within the affected area; and
 - 30.2.4 Include requirements for CAB's communication with ASI NA providing information on the CAB's current and expected future situation;
 - 30.2.5 Consider guidance provided in IAF Informative Document 3 (IAF ID 3:2011).
- 30.3 Any deviations from the established certification scheme requirements should be justified, documented and made available to ASI NA upon request.

ANNEX 1: SITUATIONS LEADING TO SANCTIONS

Table 1: Situations leading to Sanctions

Situations leading to Sanctions	Minimal Sanction and typical progression
1) Lack of collaboration in providing information as defined in section 24 of this procedure.	Formal warning → Intensification of surveillance → Suspension
2) Lack of collaboration with scheduling or undergoing ASI NA Assessments.	Formal warning → Suspension
3) Improper use of the certificate of Accreditation or of the ASI NA Logo and Accreditation Claims (ASI NA-POL-20-108).	Formal warning → Suspension
4) Non-payment of ASI NA fees as per section 23 of this procedure.	Formal warning → financial probation → Suspension due to non-payment of fees
5) Discrediting or damaging the reputation of ASI NA and/or its SOs (e.g. making or supporting incorrect public negative and/or incorrect criticizing statements about ASI NA and SO systems, processes and teams).	Suspension → Withdrawal
6) Recommendations from one Assessment (beyond NCs) or from the Accreditation or Reaccreditation process based on evaluation of CAB performance and their compliance with Accreditation requirements. For example: a) An Assessment recommending Suspension. b) PM recommending Suspension in the Accreditation Report. c) The AC recommending Suspension within their review.	Intensification of surveillance → Suspension
7) Failure to submit RCA, Correction and planned Corrective Actions for NCs within the specified deadlines (ref. ASI NA-PRO-20-107).	Formal warning → Suspension
8) Failure to implement effective Corrections and/or Corrective Actions, thereby not allowing ASI to close a major NC within the specified deadlines (ref. ASI NA-PRO-20-107).	Formal warning → Suspension
9) Failure to comply with clause 17.9 of this procedure for the Reaccreditation process.	Suspension
10) Serious breach of Accreditation Requirements. For example, but not limited to: a) Offering Certification Activity outside the Scope of Accreditation; b) Not ensuring clear impartiality of Certification Activities; c) Providing consultancy (paid or unpaid) during the certification process; d) Violation of restrictions imposed during a Suspension (e.g. issue new Certifications)	Suspension or Withdrawal

11) Performing Certification Activities/services in a region without satisfying the necessary legal requirements (e.g. local laws, permits, etc.)	Scope reduction, Suspension or Withdrawal
12) Negligent provision of false information or non-disclosure of information by a CAB relevant for an Assessment or Accreditation Decision concerning said CAB.	Suspension → Withdrawal
13) Willful deceit of ASI by intentional submission of false and/or concealment of information needed for ASI to implement its Accreditation process.	Show cause notice →Withdrawal
14) Evidence of fraudulent behavior, such as fraudulent Audits or Certification decisions.	Show cause notice →Withdrawal
15) Breach of obligations in ASI Service Agreement. For example, but not limited to: a. Breach of confidentiality agreements	Formal warning → Suspension or Withdrawal
16) Failure to correct the conditions that led to Suspension within the deadlines established.	Withdrawal

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